GUIDEBOOK

BEFORE THE FEED

STEP 01
Before the feed

Set up the high chair

Put the high chair at the table before you get baby.

Fasten all the straps — both the shoulder ones and the crotch strap.

If he/she can slide out, it's not tight enough. The tray should be at elbow height so he/she's not reaching up or hunching down.

STEP 02
Before the feed

Once you're holding baby, you won't be able to walk away.

Before you sit down: bowl of food, spoon, bib, a damp cloth for her face, and a cup of water if she's over 6 months.

Put them all on the tray or right next to you.

Get everything within arm's reach

STEP 03
Before the feed

Test the food temperature

Drop a small amount on the inside of your wrist. It should feel neutral — not warm, not cold.

Never microwave and serve immediately — always stir and test after.

If it feels warm to you,
it's too hot for baby.
Wait two minutes and test again.

STEP 04
Before the feed

Don't start a feed if she's overtired, just woken up, or already crying. She won't eat, and you'll both end up frustrated.

The best time is when she's been awake for about an hour, had a short milk feed to take the edge off hunger, and seems curious and alert.

If she's grumpy, give it 10 minutes.

Check baby's mood before you start

STEP 05
Before the feed

Check the food card before you start. If it's a new food, you're only giving a tiny amount today — 1 small spoon — and you'll do the same food for the next 3 days before adding anything new.

If it's a food she's had before, you know the drill.

Check the calendar to see if there's anything specific planned for today.

Know what you're feeding

DURING THE FEED

STEP 01
During the feed

Let him/her lead the pace

Hold the spoon out and wait for him/her to open his/her mouth.

Don't push the spoon in.
Don't make aeroplane noises to distract him/her into opening up — that's not teaching her to eat, it's tricking her.

When she opens her mouth, bring the spoon to her — not her head to the spoon.

Let him/her close his/her lips around it and pull back slightly.

STEP 02
During the feed

Talk to him/her the whole time

This feels awkward at first but it matters. Name the food: "This is broccoli — it's green and it smells strong."

Tell her what you're doing:
"Here comes the spoon."

React to her face:
"You're not sure about that one, are you?"

She's learning language, texture, and that mealtimes are a good experience. Your voice makes her feel safe.

STEP 03
During the feed

Watch for baby's stop signals

The baby will tell you when he/she's done. He/She'll turn her head away, close his/her mouth, lean back, push the spoon away, or start playing with the food.

When the baby does any of these, stop.
Don't try one more spoon.
Don't say "just one more bite."
He/She decides when he/she's full — not you.
Forcing it makes mealtimes stressful and he/she'll start refusing before you even get started.

STEP 04
During the feed

If the baby refuses a food

Don't panic and don't give up on that food. It can take 10 to 15 tries before a baby accepts a new taste. Tomorrow, try again.

If she refuses 3 days in a row, try mixing a small amount into something she already likes — carrot purée into porridge, for example.

Keep the amount tiny at first. Never force it and never show that you're frustrated — she picks up on your mood immediately.

AFTER THE FEED

STEP 01
After the feed

Clean up baby first

Wipe her face before you take her out of the chair, food on her hands and face will end up everywhere the moment she's free.

Use a warm damp cloth and be gentle around her mouth. Take the bib off last.

If she's 6 months or older, offer a few sips of water from a cup — not a bottle.

STEP 02
After the feed

Open the Recording Book now, while it's fresh. Write down what she ate, roughly how much, and how she reacted.

Was she excited? Uncertain?
Did she refuse anything?
Were there any changes to her skin or behaviour in the hour after?

This record matters — it helps you spot patterns, track allergies, and remember what works.
It also means mum doesn't have to ask "what did she eat?" every time.

Record the meal

STEP 03
After the feed

Mark the food card

If this was a new food, circle which day of the 3-day check you're on.

Mark her reaction with the emoji on the front of the card — loved it, unsure, refused, or possible reaction.

If it's day 3 and there's been no reaction, that food is now safe. Put a tick on the card.

STEP 04
After the feed

If today included a new food, keep an eye out for: skin rash or hives, swelling around the mouth or eyes, vomiting beyond normal spit-up, unusual crying or irritability, changes in nappy.

If you see any of these, stop that food and contact your GP.

If there's swelling of the face or difficulty breathing, call 999 immediately.

Watch for reactions over the next 24 hours